



Build an operational readiness audit checklist: 7 pillars of production safety, unbuilt dependencies, and recovery runbooks

Computer

Production readiness review template: audit your architecture for observability, security, capacity, and rollback gaps

Computer

Build a master operating plan template

Create a launch readiness review gate

Define the core workstream owners

I created the **Semester Operational Readiness Pack** as a reusable launch and production-safety template. It includes the master operating plan, seven production-safety pillars, dependency register, recovery runbooks, workstream owners, launch gate, sign-off record, and operating cadence.

Production readiness should be treated as a decision based on evidence—not simply whether the feature deploys. Core practices include monitoring, incident response, security controls, data recovery, performance/capacity validation, rollback planning, and accountable operational ownership. [¹¹⁹²][¹⁷³³]

Master operating plan

The operating plan template makes each initiative accountable and measurable. Every line item should include:

```
Initiative
Workstream
Outcome
Scope and exclusions
Customer/module impact
DRI and backup owner
Dependencies
Budget
Risk tier
Target date
Required evidence
Launch gate
Success metric
Status
```

Open risks/exceptions
Next review date

The five permanent workstreams are:

Workstream	Mission	Accountable owner
Product & Engineering	Build a coherent, accessible, reliable platform	Product/technical lead
Trust & Compliance	Prove security, privacy, accessibility, AI, and interoperability controls	Security/privacy/trust lead
Customer Delivery	Implement, train, support, measure, renew, and offboard customers	Customer-success/implementation lead
Commercial	Create demand, sell pilots, manage contracts, forecast, and renew	Founder/revenue lead
Corporate Operations	Run entity, finance, people, insurance, legal, vendors, and governance	Founder/operations/finance lead

Seven production-safety pillars

Pillar	Core question	Required proof
Reliability and failure behavior	Does Semester fail safely and clearly?	SLOs, dependency map, graceful-degradation tests, status-page/runbook evidence
Data integrity and recovery	Can you prevent, detect, reconcile, and recover from data loss or corruption?	Backup restore, migration, reconciliation, deletion/legal-hold, ledger tests
Observability and incident response	Can you detect, communicate, and resolve incidents?	Metrics/logs/traces, alert tests, incident tabletop, postmortem process
Security, privacy, and access control	Are users, tenants, secrets, staff access, and data protected?	MFA/RBAC/RLS tests, access review, scans, data map, vendor controls
Performance, capacity, and cost	Can it handle start-of-term, deadline, assessment, and grade-release peaks?	Load testing, budgets, capacity plan, low-bandwidth testing, FinOps evidence
Release and dependency management	Can you release, roll back, and survive vendor/dependency changes?	CI/CD gates, release manifest, feature flags, migration plan, dependency register
Support, accessibility, and ownership	Can every user complete work, recover, get help, and know who owns the problem?	Accessibility evidence, support workflow, knowledge base, module-owner register

Launch readiness gate

The pack includes three decision outcomes:

GO
All mandatory controls pass.

GO WITH CONDITIONS
No PO risk remains; remaining conditions are owned, time-bound,

mitigated, and clearly communicated.

NO-GO

Any PO or mandatory gate failure remains:

security/privacy risk, critical accessibility failure, data-loss or grade-integrity risk, unsupported claim, untested recovery path, or absent accountable owner.

Mandatory gates

Semester should not go live without evidence for:

Defined scope and exclusions

Named product, technical, support, and risk owners

Data map, permissions, retention, source/freshness, export/deletion behavior

Authentication, tenant isolation, secrets, audit logging, vulnerability controls

Accessible critical-path testing and documented alternatives

Monitoring, alerts, SLOs, status communications, and runbooks

Backup restore, rollback, reconciliation, and failure simulation

Performance and capacity testing for material workflows

AI controls and evaluation, if AI is enabled

Integration sandbox/reconciliation/fallback tests, if integrations are enabled

Support, training, hypercare, contracts, entitlements, billing, and exit terms

Stored test evidence, approvals, and time-bound exception records

Core workstream owners

The pack separates ordinary ownership from high-risk decision rights.

Product owner:

Problem, roadmap, user outcome, scope, design quality.

Engineering owner:

Architecture, delivery, performance, release, technical debt.

Security/privacy owner:

Access, data use, vendor review, risk register, incidents, evidence.

Accessibility owner:

WCAG testing, ACR/VPAT, remediation, alternatives, disabled-user impact.

AI owner:

Model/provider approval, evaluations, policy, misuse controls, AI incidents.

Implementation owner:

Tenant configuration, training, rollout, adoption, pilot outcomes.

Support/operations owner:

Support queue, escalation, status communications, runbooks, incidents.

Revenue owner:

Pricing, pipeline, proposals, contract flow, forecast, discount discipline.

Corporate operations owner:
Entity, accounting, insurance, people, vendors, governance.

No production system, integration, customer implementation, source, or runbook should ever depend on only one person. Every one needs a DRI, backup owner, review date, and escalation path.

Recovery runbooks

The template includes a standard runbook structure:

```
Detect
→ Triage scope and impact
→ Contain using feature flags, tenant isolation, read-only mode,
  credential revocation, or write freeze
→ Communicate internally and to customers
→ Recover using documented technical/manual steps
→ Validate data, user flows, audit/reconciliation, and monitoring
→ Close through root cause and tracked corrective actions
```

It specifies minimum runbooks for authentication, database/restore, deployment rollback, authorization/tenant isolation, integration failure, grade reconciliation, assessment submission, AI-provider incidents, payment errors, upload/malware failures, security incidents, abuse events, cloud outages, vendor failures, and customer-admin misconfiguration.

The full **Semester Operational Readiness Pack** is available in the file panel.

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1. <https://getdx.com/blog/production-readiness-checklist/>
2. <https://sthenotechnologies.com/production-readiness-checklist/>